

50% OF COUPLES BELIEVE SEX IS A SOURCE OF PLEASURE

Methodology: Sex and Marriage 2007

A total of 2,563 couples between 21 and 50 years of age, across 11 cities ranging from Mumbai and Delhi to Lucknow and Ludhiana were interviewed as part of the INDIA TODAY AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG Sex Survey 2007. The respondents belonged to three age groups: 21-30 years; 31-40 years and 41-50 years, from the middle and upper middle-class (Sec A and Sec B) socio-economic strata. They were divided almost equally between two age groups—1,384 in the 21-35 years category and 1,179 in the 36-50 years category. There was a set of questions that was prepared exclusively for the 1,274 male respondents, while some questions were only for the 1,289 women. The couples were asked basic demographic questions and were assured of confidentiality. Even though a system of secret ballot was used, the couples refused to answer a lot of questions. The survey covered a vast range of topics and gives an insight into the different facets of sexuality of married men and women—from satisfaction in their sex lives to the issues of family planning, and how social set-ups like joint family and work affect their married lives.

Snapshot 2004

Street-corner sampling was used to target 2,499 male respondents across 11 cities rather than direct interviews. The age group covered was between 18 and 55 years and the men belonged to the middle and upper middle-class (Sec A and Sec B). The survey turned up contrasts as far as the sexual fetishes, fantasies and expectations of men were concerned. With Lolita-esque fantasies, 45 per cent of men preferred much younger partners. Where 54 per cent went for the traditional sari-clad woman, giving vent to their nice-woman fantasies, 21 per cent had a fetish for women with long nails, long hair and loud make-up. An equal number even liked women in leopard-print lingerie. The survey revealed that Indian men still fantasised about actors—Aishwarya Rai topped the list with 6 per cent of men fantasising about her—while 16 per cent fantasised about having sex with acquaintances.

Snapshot 2003

In 2003, 2,305 women were interviewed across 10 cities belonging to three age groups: 19-24 years, 25-34 years and 35-50 years, and included those who were unmarried, married, divorced/separated or widowed. The survey showed up women who were perhaps giving their sexual side free play but who still wanted to be good wives or girlfriends. Fifteen per cent said they would have sex even if they were not in love with their partner and 58 per cent even disclosed the number of sexual partners they had had. Twenty-two per cent said they had extra marital affairs mostly with their spouse's friends. However, 85 per cent still had their first tryst with sexuality only after marriage.

**26% OF THOSE WHO HAD LOVE MARRIAGES
ADMITTED HAVING EXTRA MARITAL AFFAIRS**



ried lives. Add to it the act of sex itself being hasty (70 per cent spend less than 10 minutes on foreplay compared to a majority of American couples spending over 25 minutes making love) and where exactly does that leave the principle of pleasure in marriage? More precisely where does that leave marriage, still overwhelmingly arranged for Indians who clearly seem to regard the institution as a family rather than an individual unit? Especially when the survey shows that the family that stays together doesn't stray—couples who live in joint families tend to have more sex than those in nuclear families.

Clearly, the woman's sentiments have outstripped her circumstances. If in the 2003 survey 57 per cent of the women said an orgasm was important for their sexual fulfilment, now

a mere 28 per cent say they always have an orgasm. Yet, they are more open to foreplay and are also willing to talk about it this year. From 27 per cent women in 2003 pleading ignorance about foreplay, only 11 per cent didn't know about it today. If the men could tune in to the women's frequency, it would make their marriage the funfair they seem to want.

One of the essayists has written potently about a new definition of marriage and pointed to the lack of friendship—not love—that makes for unhappy marriages. It doesn't mean the death of desire. The alternative to coercion is caring, as sociologist Ravi Nandan Singh puts it, but it is not one the woman can apply alone. It just requires the man to wake up and smell the morning coffee or tea—preferably from a pot he has made himself. A marriage is made up of a thousand such gestures, and not all of them need to be made in bed.

with Bushra Ahmed